

# Assessing the Importance of Sex and Disease-Specific Anatomy in Electrophysiology and Mechanical Simulations with a Newly Developed Public Virtual Cohort of Four-Chamber Heart Models

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## Abstract

This work presents a study on how [differences in cardiac anatomy attributed to](#)<sup>JASL</sup> sex and disease can influence cardiac electrophysiology and mechanics using a virtual cohort of four-chamber heart models. Patient anatomy varies across sex and disease. However, capturing this variation in in-silico studies remains poorly accounted for, with studies often using either single representative cases or imbalanced virtual cohorts. Whole-heart electromechanics models incorporate the patient's anatomy, electrophysiology and mechanics across different scales, from molecular, tissue and whole-heart and circulatory system levels. However, cardiac models are typically built from one or a small number of anatomies, with sex rarely reported and the effects of anatomical variability, which include those due to sex or disease, largely unexplored. This limits clinical translation and reduces regulatory credibility.

We developed fifty patient-specific anatomical models of 25 male and 25 female hearts in heart failure and control cases. We ran benchmark passive inflation and paced activation simulations with consistent parameters and boundary conditions across cases to isolate the impact of anatomical variations with sex and disease.

Heart failure models exhibited increased chamber volumes, larger volume changes during inflation, and delayed activation times relative to controls. These trends were consistent across sexes, although right ventricular activation showed a significant sex-based difference.

Variations in anatomy with sex and disease have a significant impact on cardiac simulations, which support the inclusion of multiple heart anatomical models in in-silico trials. The resulting virtual cohort captures key anatomical variability and is publicly available at <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17048090> and our code is available at <https://github.com/OpenHeartDevelopers/cemrg-heartbuilder>.

# Author summary

Understanding how sex and disease affect the heart’s electrical and mechanical behaviour is essential for developing accurate and credible computational models. In this study, we built a balanced virtual cohort of fifty patient-specific, four-chamber heart models from male and female individuals with and without heart failure. We designed a single, streamlined pipeline to generate these models and ran benchmark simulations of electrical activation and passive inflation to evaluate how anatomical differences influence cardiac function.

We found that heart failure models showed larger chamber volumes, greater volume changes, and delayed activation times compared with controls. These patterns were consistent between sexes, although right ventricular activation showed a clear sex-related difference. Our results demonstrate that anatomical variability across sex and disease has a measurable effect on cardiac simulations. By releasing this virtual cohort and its underlying pipeline publicly, we aim to support reproducible and transparent in-silico studies and to advance the use of virtual populations in regulatory and clinical applications.

## 1 Introduction

Patient-specific computational models and simulations (CM&S) of the heart have increasingly been used to develop and guide clinical therapies [1], supporting the design [2, 3], evaluation [4, 5], and delivery [6, 7] of innovative clinical therapies. These models could advance personalised medicine by enabling the development and in-silico testing of therapies tailored to the anatomical and physiological features of individual patients. However, the creation of credible and trustworthy cardiac models remains challenging [8, 9].

There is growing support for the use of simulations for regulatory submission by the Medicines and Healthcare products Regulatory Agency [10], European Medicines Agency [11], and U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) [9, 12]. In particular, the FDA has identified scientific gaps and challenges that have limited the credibility of simulation models intended for medical use, including (i) insufficient analytic methods, (ii) lack of established credibility assessment tools, (iii) absence of best-practice guidelines, and (iv) limited availability of high-quality, comprehensive data sets [12].

Data scarcity remains a fundamental obstacle to the development of robust cardiac models, particularly the lack of high-quality, sex-balanced, disease-specific patient data. Several studies have attempted to bridge this gap through the creation of virtual cohorts that can be used for in-silico trials [13, 14]. Despite these advances, addressing sex balance in cardiac modeling databases is a persisting challenge. The cohorts of cases presented by [13] has one female patient, while the one presented by [14] has 6 out of 20. Finally, in the study by [15] on predicting atrial fibrillation recurrence, 28 of the 99 patients were female. Large virtual heart cohorts have begun to emerge, enabling in-silico trials and population-level analyses [16–18]. For example, the [13] database has been widely used for studies on valve mechanics [19], fibrosis detection [20], and arrhythmia modeling [21]. While these cohorts represent valuable tools for the cardiac modelling community, they also highlight the challenge of having balanced representation of sex or disease subtypes, and workflows for generating new whole-heart cohorts remain poorly defined.

Sex bias is a complex, multi-factorial problem that affects the availability and generalisability of data used for CM&S [22]. Simulation studies can take considerable time and computational resources, which makes it especially relevant to consider whether anatomical differences associated with sex or disease influence the results. The

impact of such variation on simulation outcomes as well as on cardiac function is not frequently explored or understood. Understanding this relationship is key to determining when sex-specific anatomical data should be included in model development and evaluation.

Testing the importance of anatomical variability requires creating sex balanced virtual cohorts. However, building a model of the whole heart is a labour-intensive and technically demanding task. Available solutions involve multiple stages: image segmentation, mesh generation, and the assignment of fibre orientations. Some approaches have explored the use of deep learning to automate aspects of mesh generation [23]. However, these methods are typically limited to single cardiac chambers rather than full four-chamber models.

CemrgApp [24] is an open-source medical imaging platform with image processing toolkits for cardiovascular research, that has a low barrier to entry and low learning curve, putting reproducibility and best practices at the forefront. CemrgApp has enabled semi-automated creation of high-quality left atrial models and has been employed in studies involving atrial fibrosis characterisation [25], motion quantification [26], and regional strain analysis [27]. However, the extension of such tools to comprehensive whole-heart modelling, including all four chambers, has not been systematically demonstrated or standardised.

In this study, we ~~developed~~<sup>JASL</sup> present CEMRG Heartbuilder, a Python-based library designed to systematically generate patient-specific, four-chamber heart models from clinical computerised tomography (CT) data. ~~Our workflow integrates custom image analysis routines with wrappers for external tools, building upon the reproducible and user-friendly CemrgApp platform.~~<sup>JASL</sup> We applied the workflow to a new cohort of 50 patients (balanced by sex), classified into three clinical groups: controls ( $n = 26$ ), heart failure with narrow QRS ( $n = 12$ ), and heart failure with wide QRS ( $n = 12$ ). For each case, models were created from a CT scan to a simulation-ready mesh with fibres, and subsequently used to run benchmark electrophysiological and mechanical simulations. ~~We applied this workflow to a cohort of 50 patients, balanced by sex, including healthy controls and two heart failure subtypes (narrow and wide QRS). Benchmark simulations with uniform material properties isolated the impact of anatomical differences attributed to sex and disease on cardiac electrophysiology and mechanics.~~<sup>JASL</sup> The simulations demonstrated the feasibility and robustness of the approach, and, through the use of uniform material properties, isolated the impact of disease and sex differences in anatomy on reference mechanical and electro physiological simulations. ~~The results demonstrate the feasibility and robustness of the approach.~~<sup>JASL</sup> ~~The aim of this study is to develop a workflow for creating hearts, apply the workflow to create a new open source sex balanced control and disease cohort, and test the impact of sex and disease differences in anatomy on reference simulations.~~<sup>JASL</sup> Figure 1 provides an overview of the pipeline and the resulting cohort.<sup>JASL</sup> ~~Figure 1 provides an overview of the workflow and resulting cohort.~~<sup>JASL</sup>

## 2 Study population

Fifty cases were processed, creating patient-specific four-chamber heart models. The cohort was split into three groups: Controls ( $C$ ,  $n = 26$ ), Heart Failure ( $HF$ ) with narrow QRS ( $HF_N$ ,  $n = 12$ ), and HF with wide QRS ( $HF_W$ ,  $n = 12$ ); each group is balanced by sex (50% Female). A QRS duration of less than 120 ms is considered narrow. Each case consisted of a CT scan. The study was conducted under ethical approval titled Retrospective analysis of cardiac imaging datasets for development of novel biomarkers study (Short title: RAIDER), approved by GSTT, reference number 306914, protocol version 1.0 01/10/2021. A summary of the cohort's demographics is



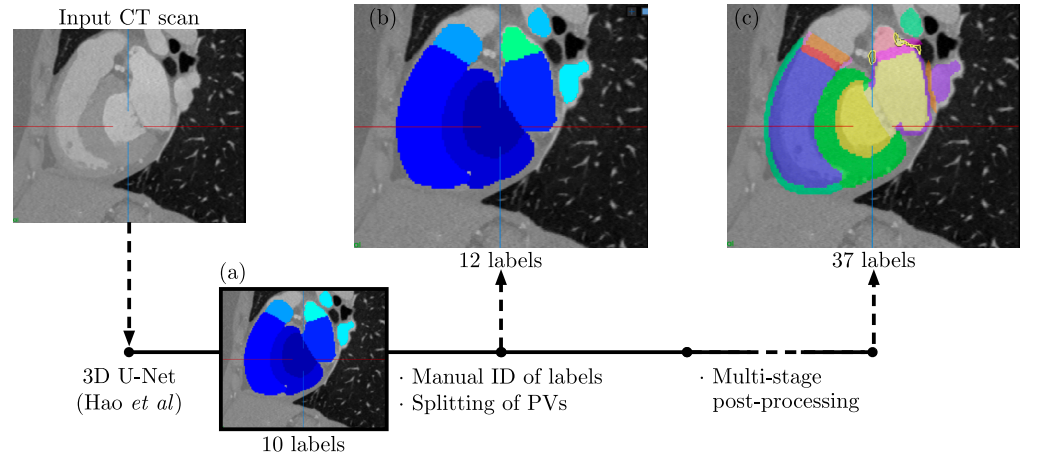


consisting of a multi-stage segmentation (Section 3.1.1), upsampling, and mesh generation (Section 3.1.2); mesh processing and model creation, which includes the assignment of fibre orientations in the ventricles and atria, and the tagging of the mesh with the different labels needed for the simulations (Section 3.2); and simulations. The multi-stage segmentation and mesh extraction substages are open source, whilst some of the mesh post-processing and simulation stages use the cardiac arrhythmia research package (CARP) [28]. Note that the modular structure of the CEMRG Heartbuilder allows for third-party projects to be included to be made completely open source.

### 3.1 Image to Mesh Stage

#### 3.1.1 Multi-stage Segmentation

The image to mesh stage consists of a segmentation of the CT scan via the deep learning model by [29], Figure 2a, which identifies 10 distinct regions: left ventricle myocardium, and blood pools of the left and right ventricles, the left and right atrium, the pulmonary artery, the aorta, the left and right atrial pulmonary veins, and left atrial appendage. Regions are marked in the segmentation with different integer values, we refer to these as “labels” throughout the manuscript. The user then identifies the different labels in the U-Net output, which splits the pulmonary veins into the superior and inferior veins. The user selects two sets of 3 points to identify the location and orientation of the superior and the inferior venae cavae. A post-processing stage follows, increasing the number of labels to 37 (Figure 2b). This stage creates the myocardia, valve planes, and vein rings. The myocardia of the right ventricle (RV), the atria, the aorta and pulmonary artery are extracted through the use of distance maps, with a user-selected thickness of 3.5mm for the RV, and 2mm for the remaining structures and coupling the different regions to ensure no overlap occurs. A table of the labels is provided in the Supplementary material.



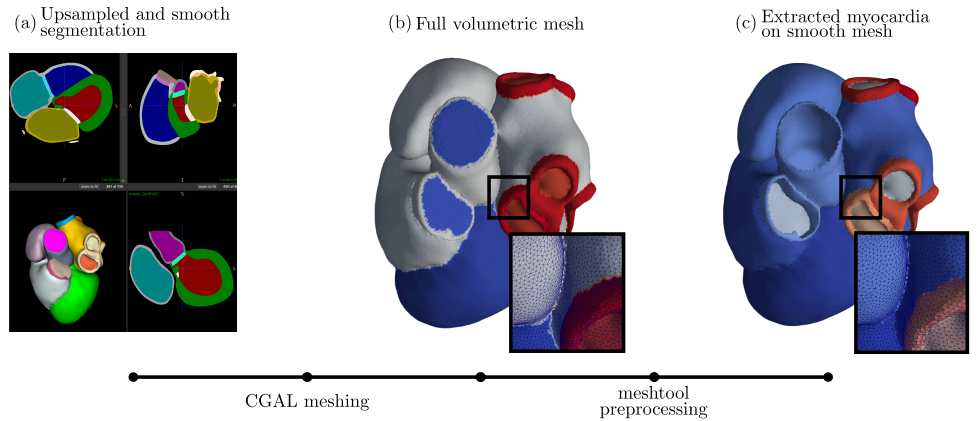
**Fig 2. Multi-stage segmentation process.** CemrgApp uses the deep learning model developed by [29] to segment the heart. (a) The output of the U-Net model, which identifies 10 regions, or “labels”, as described in the text. (b) The output of the intermediate stage, where the user manually splits the pulmonary veins into superior and inferior. (c) The final output of the post-processing stage, where the myocardium of the different structures is extracted, increasing the number of labels to 37. The final segmented images are then upsampled to an isotropic resolution of 0.1mm and smoothed.

CemrgApp aggregates the different workflows through a combination of code

running natively on the app and a docker wrapper, which calls the segmentation and different post-processing stages. The image analysis stage finalises by upsampling the 37-label segmentation to an isotropic resolution of 0.15mm, and a applies a smoothing algorithm [30].

### 3.1.2 Conversion to Mesh

A volumetric mesh is extracted from the smooth segmentation using a meshing tool developed in-house, which comes packaged with CemrgApp and is based on the Computational Geometry Algorithm Library (CGAL) [31]. The next step is to extract the myocardia, simplify the mesh topology, and relabel the tags using meshtool [32]. The simplification consists in identifying elements insufficiently connected to neighbours of the same class. A complete description of the CGAL parameters, which can be modified by the user, is available in the Supplementary material. Figure 3 shows the output of the meshing process from the smooth segmentation to the working mesh re-labelled and with the blood pools removed.



**Fig 3. Output of the meshing process from the smooth segmentation to the final working mesh.** (a) The upsampled and smooth segmentation. (b) The mesh extracted from the segmentation using the CGAL meshing tool. It contains all the blood pool and myocardium of the different structures. (c) The final mesh after the relabelling, cleaning, smoothing, and extracting only the myocardia and valve planes. Other outputs are created from this final process, such as specific endocardial and epicardial surface meshes for the atria, which will be used later in the process.

## 3.2 Mesh Processing and Model Creation

The last stage of the pipeline included takes the smooth mesh and produces a model with fibre orientations, tagged with the different labels needed for the simulations. This stage is run using CARP and meshtool [28,32] along with the CEMRG Heartbuilder python library. Figure 4 shows a visual overview of the model creation stage, which is described in detail below.

Universal Ventricular Coordinates (UVCs) are a system of coordinates that describe the geometry of the ventricles [33]. Additionally to the ventricles, UVCs are also calculated for the atria, to provide a system of coordinates defined on the volumetric mesh that facilitated the assignment of different tags within the mesh, and of boundary conditions for the pericardium. To achieve this, the left and the right atria were treated

as an upside down single ventricle, with the apex manually placed between the two right pulmonary veins and behind the superior vena cava, respectively.

Atrial fibres are then assigned to the mesh by projecting a rule-based fibre field [34] onto the mesh using Universal Atrial Coordinates (UACs) [35]. Ventricular fibres are then assigned to the mesh using a rule-based algorithm, described by [36], which uses a series of Laplace solutions to assign the fibre direction. UACs are a system of coordinates that describe the geometry of the atria [35]. The atrial fibres, which originally are produced on surfaces, are then projected onto the 3D mesh, by assigning endocardial and epicardial fibres in the inner and outer 50% across the thickness of the atria, respectively. From the UAC pipeline, which is run through a docker container, similar to the work by [1], the sino atrial node (SAN) is also mapped from the atlas.

The mesh is tagged with the different labels needed for the simulations. First, a region representing the fast-conducting Bachmann bundle is created, to simulate fast propagation of the electrical signal from the right to the left atrium. This is done using the UVCs defined on the atria. The fast endocardial conduction layer (FEC) is also created at this stage, which is a thin layer of fast conducting tissue at the endocardium of the ventricles representing the Purkinje network. In addition, to prevent unphysiological propagation from the atria to the ventricles and to control the atrioventricular delay, the atria and the ventricles were electrically isolated from each other by defining a layer on non-conducting tissue between the atrial and ventricular myocardium. Finally, the SAN and the left and right ventricular fascicles are also created, Figure 4 (f.1, f.2, f.3). The SAN and fascicles are used to initiate electrical activation in the electrophysiology (EP) simulations. The left and right fascicles represent the first breakthrough from the Purkinje network into the myocardium to mimic the activation reported by the Durrer maps [37]. These locations are defined in UVCs based on [38].

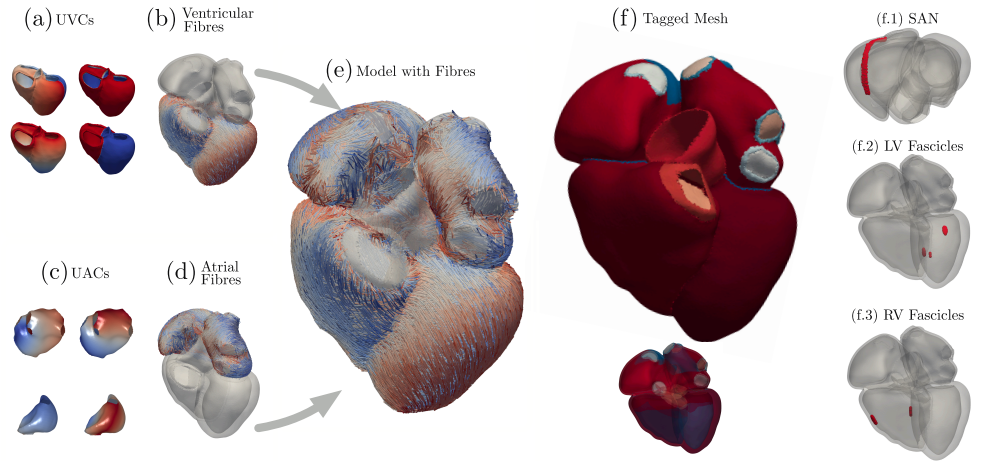
### 3.3 Simulations

We performed EP and mechanics simulations on all the models. Simulations were run with a fixed set of parameters to assess the impact anatomical differences would have on the outputs. These simulations also served as an additional quality check for the meshes, to ensure the models could be used to run electromechanics simulations.

The EP simulations were started at the SAN, defined in Section 4. The ventricular endocardial electrodes (fascicles) were also activated simulating the early activation sites [39]. The reaction-eikonal model [40] was solved to compute the activation times at each node. A conduction velocity of 1 m/s was used at the myocardial tissue, with a 40% anisotropy cross-fibre, and a 6-fold speed in the fast activation regions [41]. As output, the total activation time of each ventricle, of both ventricles and both atria were extracted.

To test how differences in anatomy impacted simulation predictions, we performed inflation simulations to evaluate the mechanical behaviour of the models. Briefly, increasing pressure is applied at the endocardium of each chamber until a maximum established pressure of 7 mmHg for the left chambers (LV and LA) and 3.5 mmHg for the right chambers (RV and RA) is reached. The myocardium was modelled as an transversely isotropic hyperelastic material using the Guccione's material law [42], while the rest of the cardiac structures were modelled as isotropic hyperelastic materials using a NeoHookean material law [43]. Mechanics simulations were run with the same boundary conditions as the work by [44], which can be consulted in the Supplementary Material.

Simulations were run to assess the impact of anatomical differences on the outputs and to serve as a quality check for the meshes. All simulations were run with



**Fig 4. Model creation stage.** Universal Ventricular coordinates (a) are calculated from the mesh, then used to assign the fibre direction (b) using a rule-based algorithm [36]. Universal Atrial coordinates (c) are calculated from the mesh, then used to assign the fibre direction (d) using a projection from an atlas [35]. The atrial fibres, which originally are produced on surfaces, are then projected onto the 3D mesh. The fibres from the ventricles and atria are then assigned to the model (e). The final mesh is tagged with the different labels needed for the simulations (f). The fast endocardial conduction layer (FEC) is also created at this stage (f - bottom), which is a thin layer of fast conducting tissue at the endocardium of the ventricles. Finally, UVCs and UACs are used to create the sino atrial node (SAN, f.1), the left ventricle fascicles (f.2) and right ventricle fascicles (f.3).

CARP [28]. The EP simulations were run in a 20-core workstation, while the inflation simulations were run in the UK national supercomputer ARCHER2, using 512 cores.

Model outputs obtained from the simulations are listed in Table 2, along with a brief description. The 18 measurements are grouped into four categories: activation times (4 outputs), inflated volume (4), volume change (absolute 4, and normalised 4), and volume ratios (2). The absolute volume change ( $\Delta\text{Vol}$ ) is calculated as the difference between the maximum and minimum volume during the inflation simulation. For simplicity, we refer to inflated volume as volume throughout the manuscript. The normalised volume change ( $\mathcal{V}$ ) is calculated as the percentage of change in volume, and the volume ratio is calculated as the ratio between the left and right volumes, this was calculated for the ventricles and the atria. The Total Activation Time (TAT) is the time it takes for the electrical signal to propagate through the entire chamber.

**Table 2. Model outputs obtained from the simulations.** The subscript  $x$  refers to the chamber, which can be left ventricle (LV), right ventricle (RV), left atrium (LA), or right atrium (RA).

| Measurement              | Symbol               | Calculation / Definition            |
|--------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Total Activation Time    | $\text{TAT}_x$       | All chambers, ventricles, and atria |
| (Inflated) Volume        | $\text{Vol}_x$       | All chambers                        |
| Volume Change            | $\Delta\text{Vol}_x$ | Maximum minus minimum volumes       |
| Normalised Volume Change | $\mathcal{V}_x$      | Percentage of change in volume      |
| Volume Ratio             | $\frac{L}{R}$        | Ratio of left and right volumes     |

**QRS duration.** Since the simulations do not include a torso, the comparison cannot be made directly with the QRS duration measured in the ECGs. Instead, we used the total activation time in the ventricles as a surrogate for QRS duration and compared it between the different groups.

**Total Activation Time in the Atria.** This parameter has emerged as a key marker of atrial remodeling and is associated with *HF* progression and complications [45, 46]. We assessed the total activation time in the atria, comparing it between the different groups.

### 3.4 Statistical tests and comparison of volume to clinical literature

We performed a multi-step statistical analysis of our cardiac dataset. First, we computed descriptive statistics (mean  $\pm$  SD) for all core metrics (volumes and activation times) stratified by sex, condition (*HF* vs. control), and subtype (*HF<sub>N</sub>* vs. *HF<sub>W</sub>*). Differences between narrow and wide QRS durations are only explored qualitatively, as the number of cases in each group is low.

**Effect sizes and statistical significance.** To assess the differences in the outcomes, we used a two-way ANOVA to test the effects of Sex, Condition, and their interaction. We followed up significant ANOVA results in the interactions with post-hoc pairwise comparisons using Tukey’s method, and calculated Cohen’s  $d$  effect sizes [47] for each comparison. If the interaction was not significant, we performed marginal comparisons between *HF* and controls, or male and female groups, across all cases. P-values were corrected for multiple comparisons using the Benjamini–Hochberg false discovery rate [48]. Effect sizes are reported as Cohen’s  $d$ , using Gignac’s expanded criteria [49],

where  $d < 0.5$  is small,  $0.5 < d < 0.8$  is moderate,  $0.8 < d < 1.2$  is large, and  $d > 1.2$  is very large.

To externally validate the models, we compared different outputs from the pipeline linked them to a clinically relevant metrics.

**Left atrial and left ventricular volume.** Left atrial volume is a predictor of outcome in patients with chronic *HF*, independently of their symptoms, age, or LV function [50]. LV volume is a key prognostic factor in *HF*, as it is associated with the severity of the disease and the risk of adverse events [51,52]. We assessed the left atrial volume ( $\text{Vol}_{LA}$ ) and LV volume ( $\text{Vol}_{LV}$ ) in the models, comparing between the different groups. For  $\text{Vol}_{LV}$ , we compared measurements from our cohort with reference values from the UK biobank (UKBB) [53], which defines normal ranges for left and right ventricles in males and females. Outside the normal ranges, we considered the volumes to be abnormal, and therefore indicative of *HF* or other cardiac conditions.

## 4 Results

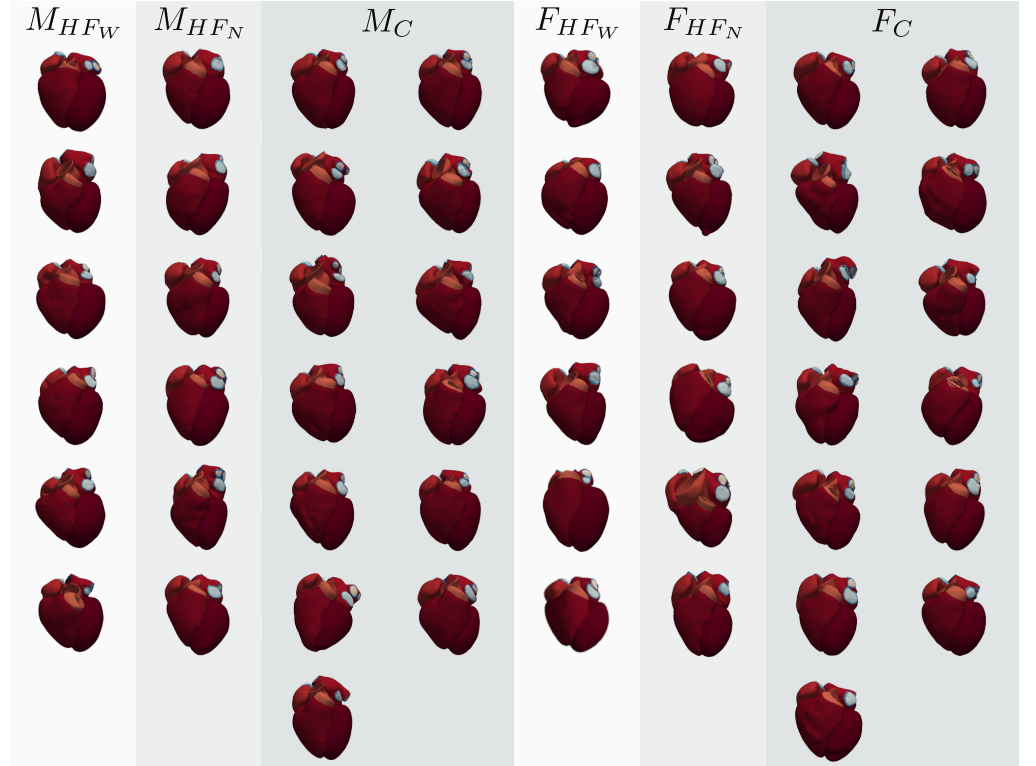
Fifty whole-heart models (Figure 5) were created, each including EP and mechanics simulations described in Section 3.3. All simulations were performed with the same parameters for each model. Therefore, the differences in simulations between sexes reported below relate to differences in anatomy. We first examined the distributions of all core metrics across sex and condition. A full table of means and standard deviations is provided in the Supplementary Material. We found no significant difference in age between males and females (M:  $53.4 \pm 15.0$  y; F:  $54.6 \pm 10.7$  y;  $p = 0.75$ ).

Next, we assessed model volumes and the outputs of the EP and mechanics simulations. In each case, we report the results from the two-way ANOVA and the post-hoc tests, showing the effect sizes. Where no interaction was present, we examined independent effects. In both cases, only statistically significant results after FDR correction are reported here. Effect sizes were computed using Cohen's  $d$  and are visualised in Figure 7.

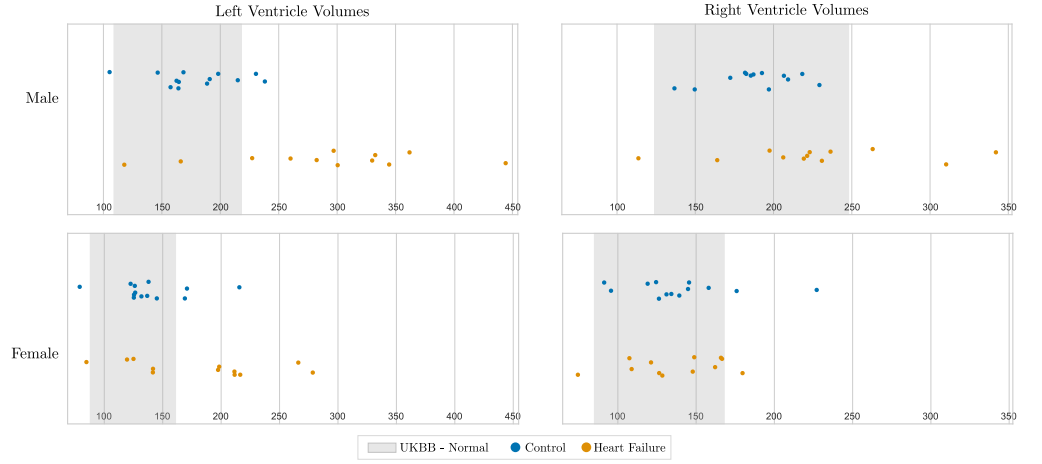
**LV volume.**  $\text{Vol}_{LV}$  was significantly larger in *HF* patients and showed a significant interaction ( $p < 0.05$  in ANOVA and all post-hoc comparisons). For all but three male controls, the LV volumes fall within the normal range ([109, 218] mL) compared to the UKBB reference values [53]. Similarly, female controls also fall mostly within their corresponding normal range ([88, 161] mL). We display the results in Figure 6. The effects sizes were also large between *HF* and control groups, but they were much larger in males than in females, for instance, interactions involving females ranged between  $0.9 < d < 1.17$ , while interactions involving males were higher than  $d > 1.4$  ( $p < 0.05$  in all cases, Figure 7(a)).

**Volume change in the LV.** We used volume change as a surrogate for stiffness. LV volume change was significantly larger in males compared to females and in *HF* patients compared to controls (both main effects with  $p < 0.01$ ), but we did not detect a significant sex  $\times$  condition interaction ( $p = 0.44$ ), indicating that sex and condition contribute independently to LV volume change. The effect sizes were large, with  $d = 0.94$ ,  $p < 0.01$  for *HF* vs controls, and  $d = 0.78$ ,  $p < 0.01$  for male vs female comparisons (Figure 7(b)).

**Activation times.** For ventricular  $\text{TAT}_V$ , no significant interaction was found between sex and condition ( $p = 0.76$ ), however, the independent effect sizes were large.



**Fig 5. Three-dimensional whole-heart reconstructions from the virtual cohort, grouped and labelled by sex and condition.** Each colour corresponds to a different structure in the mesh. Each model was derived from a patient's CT scan and includes fibre orientations, illustrating anatomical variability across sex and heart-failure subtypes. Abbreviations:  $M_{HF_N}$ : Male, HF narrow-QRS;  $M_{HF_W}$ : Male, HF wide-QRS;  $M_C$ : Male, Control;  $F_{HF_N}$ : Female, HF narrow-QRS;  $F_{HF_W}$ : Female, HF wide-QRS;  $F_C$ : Female, Control.



**Fig 6. Comparison of measured ventricle volumes from the virtual cohort with clinical literature values and ranges from UKBB.** The UKBB normal ranges are defined as measurements within the 95% prediction interval of the study by [53]. Two graphs, corresponding to the LV and RV metrics and reference volumes. Each plot is separated by sex and coloured by condition, with Controls in blue and Heart Failure in orange. Normal ranges are shown as greyed areas, and exceeding the upper limit of the reference range may indicate pathological ventricular dilation.

First,  $TAT_V$  was significantly longer in males compared to females ( $d = 1.4, p < 0.01$ ), and in  $HF$  patients compared to controls ( $d = 0.72, p = 0.014$ ).  $TAT_{LA}$  showed a similar pattern. First, no significant interaction between sex and condition was found ( $p = 0.24$ ). Second, the independent effects were significant and moderate, showing prolonged activation times in  $HF$  vs. controls ( $d = 0.62, p < 0.05$ ) and prolonged activation in males vs. females ( $d = 0.59, p < 0.05$ ).

**Normalised volume changes in LV.**  $V_{LV}$  showed a significant interaction in the ANOVA between sex and condition ( $p < 0.05$ ). Post-hoc tests only showed effects sizes were significant when comparing

Male  $HF$  vs. male controls ( $d = -1.33$ ),

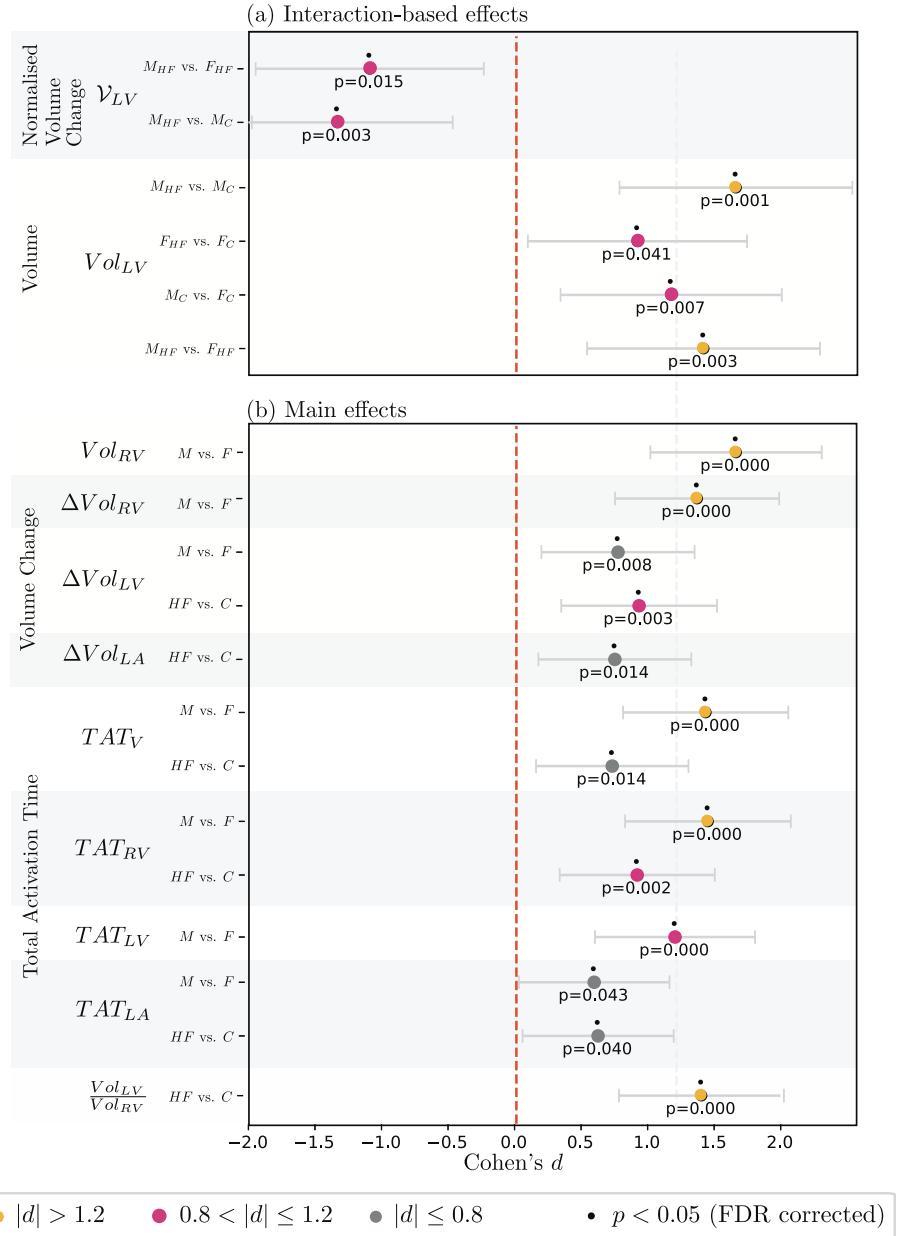
Male vs. female with  $HF$  ( $d = -1.09$ ), both with  $p < 0.05$ .

## 5 Discussion

We created a sex-balanced virtual cohort of 50 whole-heart models derived from clinical CT scans of both healthy individuals and  $HF$  patients. We used a semi-automated pipeline to generate these models, which includes segmentation, mesh generation, fibre orientation assignment, and simulation setup. The models enabled the exploration of differences in volume, and activation time across sex and disease groups, using benchmark electrophysiology and mechanics simulations. With this study, we demonstrate that anatomical differences between sexes and across disease states have a significant impact on both electrical and mechanical simulation predictions in the heart. This highlights the critical need to account for such variations when developing and applying computational models in cardiology.

A variety of computational pipelines have been proposed to construct heart models, ranging from atria-only or ventricles-only representations to anatomically detailed four-chamber reconstructions. The works by [54] and [55] proposed patient-specific





**Fig 7. Cohen's d effect sizes from post-hoc comparisons following two-way ANOVA.** Metrics and group comparisons are displayed on the y-axis. This graph only shows effects with a high effect size and a corrected p-value  $p < 0.05$ . (a) Effect sizes for group comparisons performed when the Sex  $\times$  Condition interaction was statistically significant, justifying 4 simple-effect post-hoc tests. (b) Effect sizes for marginal comparisons, when no significant interaction was found. *Abbreviations:* M=Male, F=Female; C=Control, HF=Heart Failure; TAT=Total Activation time, L/R=Left/Right, V=Ventricle.

atrial models, including anatomical regions and fibre orientations from clinical data. In contrast, other pipelines focus only on ventricular chambers [56,57]. A notable whole-heart model was developed by [58], which builds detailed four-chamber meshes of the entire heart from patient imaging and has been enhanced since to improve simulation fidelity, multi-scale integration, and clinical translation. The resulting models are anatomically detailed, but the method depended on extensive user guidance to create the initial atlas, limiting throughput and scale. Other groups [59] have also demonstrated personalised whole-heart electrophysiology models, but again with significant manual setup and typically small cohorts. In summary, existing pipelines either produce atria-only or ventricle-only models, or else deliver high-detail four-chamber meshes at the cost of manual effort. Our framework seeks to overcome these limitations by producing anatomically complete four-chamber (atria + ventricles) models with minimal manual input, combining scalability with high anatomical fidelity.

## 5.1 Building Patient-Specific Whole-Heart Models: Workflow Insights

The models were created using a standardised pipeline, CEMRG heartbuilder, which allows for the generation of patient-specific models from CT scans. The segmentation framework has enabled a substantial reduction in overall model generation time relative to earlier methods. The pipeline requires approximately 5 hours per heart on average. It is also significantly more detailed than most publicly available pipelines. For instance, methods evaluated in the MICCAI 2024 Whole Heart Segmentation Challenge [60] typically produce 7–10 output labels, insufficient for physiologically realistic biophysical simulations. In contrast, our approach employs a 37-label standard [13,61], encompassing detailed delineation of blood pools, myocardia, valve planes, and major vessels across all four chambers.

## 5.2 Impact of Anatomical Variability on Electromechanical Predictions

All whole-heart models were simulated using identical parameters for both electrophysiology and mechanics. We did not include active contraction in the benchmark as these simulations often require patient specific parameters to match contraction, pre-load and after load, reducing our ability to compare consistent simulations across anatomies. As such, the results reflect the isolated impact of structural variation due to sex or disease status on predicted electrical activation and mechanical inflation. The results from the two-way ANOVA showed, in most cases, non significant interactions. This means that we could only look at the independent effects: control vs *HF* and male vs female. The characterisation of effect sizes (small, moderate, and large) by [49], were included as a guideline, based on the distribution of effect sizes obtained.

## 5.3 Comparison with Clinical Reference Ranges

Validation against population-based MRI reference data [53] confirmed that control models reproduced expected sex-specific chamber sizes. Male and female LV and RV volumes were largely consistent with normal ranges, supporting the accuracy of our anatomical pipeline. In heart failure, LV enlargement was most pronounced in males, frequently exceeding reference thresholds, consistent with classical patterns of systolic dilation. Females also showed increased LV volumes, though these remained mostly within upper limits, highlighting sex differences in disease expression. RV enlargement was less prominent in both males and females with *HF*. This might be reflecting

clinical reports that RV size is less sensitive to early disease [62]. These results demonstrate that the virtual cohort captures both healthy anatomy and pathological remodelling, while also exposing the limitations of fixed reference ranges that do not account for sex and disease interplay.

**Impact of Sex and Heart Failure in *In-Silico* Studies** Our simulations consistently separated groups by sex and disease status, even in the absence of tuned electrophysiological or mechanical parameters. Absolute LV volume increases were particularly marked in male *HF*, reproducing the clinical signature of pathological dilation [51,52]. Larger  $\Delta\text{Vol}_{LV}$  in *HF* patients suggest structurally thinner or more distensible walls [63,64]. Similarly, larger  $\Delta\text{Vol}_{LA}$  would indicate other issues like increased prediction of mortality or hospitalisation [65,66]. When expressed as a normalised change, however, *HF* females showed the greatest relative differences, a finding likely driven by smaller baseline chamber sizes. This emphasises that absolute and relative measures provide complementary insights and must be interpreted carefully in sex-stratified analyses [22]. Electrical activation followed similar logic: ventricular and atrial activation were prolonged in *HF* and in males, consistent with clinical QRS and conduction observations [45,46], though interactions were not significant. These convergent trends across independent metrics highlight that anatomical variability alone can generate clinically relevant patterns of electromechanical behaviour, a finding consistent with model-based predictions of sex-specific conduction behaviour [67]. These findings suggest that even without personalisation of tissue properties or conduction parameters, anatomically driven whole-heart simulations can outline group-level trends in cardiac function. The consistent importance of sex and disease differences across multiple metrics reinforces the clinical relevance of the modelling pipeline and motivates its use in larger-scale studies [13].

## 5.4 Establishing Model Credibility and Validation Strategies for In Silico Clinical Trials

In silico studies using virtual cohorts of patients, referred to as in silico clinical trials (ISCTs), require careful demonstration of model credibility for their conclusions to be considered reliable. Credibility is primarily established by performing validation, that is, comparison of model predictions with real-world data. However, unlike relatively simple models of standalone medical devices, or drug safety/efficacy studies using a generic action potential model, ISCTs present a much wider range of possible validation strategies. As discussed in detail in [68], possible evaluation activities include: validation of a device/drug model in isolation (e.g., bench test validation of a pacemaker lead mechanics model); individual-level validation of patient models in the cohort (i.e., comparing predictions from a specific patient model with clinical data from the specific patient the model represents), population-level validation of the cohort or sub-cohorts (e.g., comparing the distribution of model outputs across the cohort with clinical data from the corresponding real-world population), validation of coupled device-patient or drug-patient models (e.g., PKPD validation studies), and validation of any statistical model used to convert patient model outputs into clinical endpoints. Also, there are important additional activities that should be performed, such as assessing the virtual cohort representativeness; these are not strictly model validation activities and more akin to model input validation for simple models.

Overall, an ISCT is expected to be supported by a body of evidence on model credibility. For a virtual cohort such as the sex-balanced 50 patient cohort provided here, intended for re-use in variety of future device or drug ISCTs, a hierarchical evaluation approach can be used to generate an initial body of credibility evidence to support a

future ISCT. In this work, we have performed the first steps of such a hierarchical approach, by assessing cohort representativeness (and simultaneously assessing accuracy of the model generation pipeline) through comparison the ventricular and atrial volumes in the male and female cohort subsets with corresponding UK BioBank data.

A natural next step would be to perform sex-specific population-level validation: demonstrating that the distribution of model outputs, for each of the male and female sub-cohorts, match the distribution observed in the male and female populations, particularly for outputs for which a statistically significant sex difference was observed. For instance, predicted chamber TAT distributions could be compared with sex-specific population QRS duration data, after an appropriate transformation to account for the fact that TAT is only a surrogate for QRS. Individualized validation, while more challenging, could be performed for newly generated patient models. Ultimately, these results would be supplemented by context-specific validation when the cohort is used in a device/drug ISCT, together with other credibility assessment activities such as verification and uncertainty quantification [69].

## 5.5 Limitations

This work has four main limitations that should be considered when interpreting the results. First, the small sample size within each category of *HF*, narrow and wide QRS duration, limits the statistical power for detecting subtle effects or interactions. Nonetheless, by balancing sex and *HF* subtype, our dataset offers a structured starting point for exploring sex-disease interactions in-silico. Furthermore, it can serve as a foundation for synthetic cohort generation [17, 18] with a more diverse range of anatomical and clinical characteristics. Secondly, the simulations performed in this work were benchmark simulations and the parameters were not calibrated to the individual anatomies. However, the use of a common set of parameters across all cases ensured that the differences observed in the results were purely anatomical. Third, the pipeline requires 5 hours per heart on average, with 2 hours spent performing manual corrections required at the segmentation stage. Even so, this is a significant reduction compared to previous methods. Finally, limitations remain at the segmentation stage. Because this step underpins all subsequent model construction, we discuss its implications in more detail in the following section.

### 5.5.1 Critical Role of Segmentation in Model Accuracy

The segmentation stage is a critical bottleneck in the pipeline, requiring notable manual input to ensure anatomical fidelity. The most frequent issues involve small gaps or discontinuities in the myocardium, where the wall becomes excessively thin. The segmentation method proposed by [29] is not robust against some artefacts introduced by implanted devices, such as the bright streaks caused by leads or stents in *HF* patients. Manual steps and corrections in the pipeline could potentially be replaced with more robust algorithms. For example, recent work by [70] demonstrated a foundation model capable of deriving full myocardial masks without user input. Finally, given the limited soft-tissue contrast and resolution of standard CT scans, the myocardial thickness in chambers outside of the LV is set to a user-specified constant. This approximation may not reflect the true myocardial thickness and may underestimate simulation variability.

Despite these limitations, our current approach balances physiological realism with scalability, enabling whole-heart simulations across a sizeable cohort. Incorporating more refined fibre estimation methods remains an important direction for improving predictive accuracy in personalised cardiac models. By incorporating this level of anatomical detail into a reproducible, Python-based workflow, our pipeline bridges the

gap between clinical image segmentation and simulation-ready models. It provides a  
viable route to building whole-heart virtual cohorts for in-silico trials and aligns with  
regulatory guidelines on model credibility and anatomical completeness [12].

## 6 Conclusion

We presented a cohort of 50 publicly available whole-heart simulations derived from  
patient-specific CT geometries, comprising healthy individuals and *HF* patients  
balanced by sex. The dataset offers a representative and well-characterised virtual  
cohort for in-silico cardiac research. The cohort is suitable for evaluating modeling  
assumptions, exploring anatomical variability, and help the development of  
digital-twin-style pipelines contingent on parameter calibration, data assimilation, and  
validation. Our results show that anatomical variability alone can drive consistent  
differences between groups, underscoring the need to account for both sex- and  
disease-specific features when designing and interpreting simulation studies. By  
combining anatomical fidelity with a reproducible workflow, this work provides a  
practical foundation for larger-scale investigations and the clinical translation of  
whole-heart simulations.

## List of changes

|                                                                         |   |     |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|-----|
| Added (JASL): differences in cardiac anatomy attributed to . . . . .    | 1 | 461 |
| Replaced (JASL): developed . . . . .                                    | 3 | 462 |
| Deleted (JASL): Our workflow integrates custom image [...] . . . . .    | 3 | 463 |
| Replaced (JASL): We applied the workflow to a new coho [...] . . . . .  | 3 | 464 |
| Replaced (JASL): The simulations demonstrated the feasi [...] . . . . . | 3 | 465 |
| Deleted (JASL): The aim of this study is to develop a [...] . . . . .   | 3 | 466 |
| Replaced (JASL): Figure 1 provides an overview of the [...] . . . . .   | 3 | 467 |

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